

The Gift of the Magi

O. Henry · 1905

First published: New York Sunday World, Dec 1905

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Four_Million/The_Gift_of_the_Magi (revision 13321101), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Gift of the Magi suggest about sacrificial love?
- What does The Gift of the Magi suggest about wealth and poverty?
- What does The Gift of the Magi suggest about irony of giving?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Gift of the Magi	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*sacrificial love* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Gift of the Magi

Focus: love measured by sacrifice

Content note (): No significant sensitive content flagged; preview as usual.
Student preview: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

On Christmas Eve Della Young has only $1.87 to buy a present for her husband Jim. She sells her long, beautiful hair for twenty dollars and buys a platinum fob chain for Jim's prized gold watch. Jim comes home and reveals he has sold the watch to buy Della a set of tortoise-shell combs for her hair. The narrator calls the two foolish children but declares them the wisest of givers: they are the magi.

Background: O. Henry wrote the story in 1905 for the New York Sunday World. A flat at $8 a week and a $20 salary cut place the Youngs among New York's struggling clerks.

Significance: A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Nothing in this story needs a special warning.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are ransacking, cascade, depreciate, vestibule, accurate. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "She was ransacking the stores for Jim's present." In this sentence it means: searching a place thoroughly, often roughly. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Gift of the Magi would have known. O. Henry wrote the story in 1905 for the New York Sunday World. A flat at $8 a week and a $20 salary cut place the Youngs among New York's struggling clerks. Why does this story matter? A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for irony.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to love measured by sacrifice? I circle "mendicancy", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find irony, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for irony.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of irony. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home. A furnished flat at $8 per week. It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Irony, Symbolism, Tone / mood: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Gift of the Magi develops the idea of love measured by sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to sacrificial love? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about love measured by sacrifice, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes love measured by sacrifice. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
ransacking (verb)	searching a place thoroughly, often roughly	*She was ransacking the stores for Jim's present.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cascade (noun)	a falling mass, like a waterfall	*So now Della's beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
depreciate (verb)	to belittle; to speak of as unimportant	*Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
vestibule (noun)	an entrance hall	*In the vestibule below was a letter-box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
accurate (adjective)	conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy	*A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
valuable (adjective)	useful; worth having	*The magi brought valuable gifts, but that was not among them.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mendicancy (noun)	the practice or state of begging	*It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
inconsequential (adjective)	not important	*For ten seconds let us regard with discreet scrutiny some inconsequential object in the other direction.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
meretricious (adjective)	showy but cheap or without real value	*It was a platinum fob chain simple and chaste in design, properly proclaiming its value by substance alone and not by meretricious ornamentation—as all good things should do.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
adornments (noun)	things that decorate or beautify	*And now, they were hers, but the tresses that should have adorned the coveted adornments were gone.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special?

2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with sacrificial love?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How much money does Della have at the start? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: One dollar and eighty-seven cents
2. What does Della sell? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Her hair
3. What does Della buy for Jim? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A platinum fob chain for his watch
4. What has Jim bought for Della? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A set of tortoise-shell combs
5. Why does the narrator call Jim and Della 'the magi'? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: They gave the wisest gifts, out of love
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Gift of the Magi” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: On Christmas Eve Della Young has only $1.87 to buy a present for her husband Jim. She sells her long, beautiful hair for twenty dollars and buys a platinum fob chain for Jim's prized gold watch. Jim comes home and reveals he has sold the watch to buy Della a set of tortoise-shell combs for her hair. The narrator calls the two foolish children but declares them the wisest of givers: they are the…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Gift of the Magi”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Gift of the Magi” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.” What does “ransacking” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: ransacking: searching a place thoroughly, often roughly.
10. Reread: “So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.” What does “cascade” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: cascade: a falling mass, like a waterfall.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Gift of the Magi” suggest about love measured by sacrifice? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about love measured by sacrifice? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home.”, why might Henry have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Gift of the Magi”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: On Christmas Eve Della Young has only $1.87 to buy a present for her husband Jim. She sells her long, beautiful hair for twenty dollars and buys a platinum fob chain for Jim's prized gold watch. Jim comes home and reveals he has sold the watch to buy Della a set of tortoise-shell combs for her…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Gift of the Magi” set up that the rest of The Gift of the Magi will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What is the best gift you have ever given or received, and what made it special?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with sacrificial love? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.
10. Background: O. Henry wrote the story in 1905 for the New York Sunday World. A flat at $8 a week and a $20 salary cut place the Youngs among New York's struggling clerks. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A classic of situational irony and a Common Core Appendix B grades 9–10 exemplar.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Gift of the Magi" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about love measured by sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Gift of the Magi": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to wealth and poverty: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Henry need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Gift of the Magi" treats love measured by sacrifice with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Gift of the Magi see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve sacrificial love? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about love measured by sacrifice? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask O. Henry about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz

1. How much money does Della have at the start?
   A. Eight dollars
   B. Nothing
   C. One dollar and eighty-seven cents
   D. Twenty dollars
2. What does Della sell?
   A. Her coat

B. Her watch

C. Her ring

D. Her hair

3. What does Della buy for Jim?

A. A gold ring

B. A new coat

C. A pair of gloves

D. A platinum fob chain for his watch

4. What has Jim bought for Della?

A. A mirror

B. A hat

C. A necklace

D. A set of tortoise-shell combs

5. Why does the narrator call Jim and Della 'the magi'?

A. They are kings

B. They are rich

C. They gave the wisest gifts, out of love

D. They are from the East

6. In the line “She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.”, what does “ransacking” most nearly mean?

A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly

B. an entrance hall

C. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant

D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

7. In the line “So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?

A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly

B. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant

C. an entrance hall

D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

Answer key: 1. C (One dollar and eighty-seven cents); 2. D (Her hair); 3. D (A platinum fob chain for his watch); 4. D (A set of tortoise-shell combs); 5. C (They gave the wisest gifts, out of love); 6. A (searching a place thoroughly, often roughly); 7. D (a falling mass, like a waterfall)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Gift of the Magi,” how does Henry show love measured by sacrifice? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Gift of the Magi, how does Henry develop the idea of love measured by sacrifice? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Gift of the Magi develops the idea of love measured by sacrifice. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of love measured by sacrifice. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Gift of the Magi suggests about love measured by sacrifice. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how O. Henry uses irony in The Gift of the Magi to complicate the reader's understanding of love measured by sacrifice. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Gift of the Magi within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of love measured by sacrifice responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Gift of the Magi alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of love measured by sacrifice follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Gift of the Magi and its treatment of love measured by sacrifice. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Gift of the Magi as evidence for a larger claim about love measured by

sacrifice in The Gift of the Magi. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Gift of the Magi as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of love measured by sacrifice. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Gift of the Magi.

SAT-style questions

1. *Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "depreciate" most nearly mean?

   A. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant

   B. showy but cheap or without real value

   C. not important

   D. things that decorate or beautify

2. *While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home. A furnished flat at $8 per week. It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "The Gift of the Magi"?

   A. Love measured by sacrifice

   B. Hope created by an act of sacrifice

   C. A symbol of hidden sin that isolates its wearer

   D. Science that poisons love

SAT key: 1. A (to belittle; to speak of as unimportant); 2. A (Love measured by sacrifice)

Whole-book test

The Gift of the Magi: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. How much money does Della have at the start?
   A. Eight dollars
   B. Nothing
   C. One dollar and eighty-seven cents
   D. Twenty dollars
2. What does Della sell?
   A. Her coat
   B. Her watch
   C. Her ring
   D. Her hair
3. What does Della buy for Jim?
   A. A gold ring
   B. A new coat
   C. A pair of gloves
   D. A platinum fob chain for his watch
4. What has Jim bought for Della?
   A. A mirror
   B. A hat
   C. A necklace
   D. A set of tortoise-shell combs
5. Why does the narrator call Jim and Della 'the magi'?
   A. They are kings
   B. They are rich
   C. They gave the wisest gifts, out of love
   D. They are from the East
6. In the line “She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.”, what does “ransacking” most nearly mean?
   A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
   B. an entrance hall
   C. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall

7. In the line “So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.”, what does “cascade” most nearly mean?
   A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
   B. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
   C. an entrance hall
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall
8. As used in the story (“She was ransacking the stores for Jim’s present.”), what does “ransacking” mean?
   A. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
   B. conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy
   C. not important
   D. a falling mass, like a waterfall
9. As used in the story (“So now Della’s beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters.”), what does “cascade” mean?
   A. useful; worth having
   B. a falling mass, like a waterfall
   C. showy but cheap or without real value
   D. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
10. As used in the story (“Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depr”), what does “depreciate” mean?
    A. the practice or state of begging
    B. things that decorate or beautify
    C. to belittle; to speak of as unimportant
    D. an entrance hall
11. As used in the story (“In the vestibule below was a letter-box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring.”), what does “vestibule” mean?
    A. not important
    B. searching a place thoroughly, often roughly
    C. conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy
    D. an entrance hall
12. As used in the story (“A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conc”), what does “accurate” mean?
    A. conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy
    B. showy but cheap or without real value
    C. a falling mass, like a waterfall
    D. useful; worth having

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how sacrificial love develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how wealth and poverty develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

3. Explain how irony of giving develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (sacrificial love, wealth and poverty, irony of giving) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (One dollar and eighty-seven cents); 2. D (Her hair); 3. D (A platinum fob chain for his watch); 4. D (A set of tortoise-shell combs); 5. C (They gave the wisest gifts, out of love); 6. A (searching a place thoroughly, often roughly); 7. D (a falling mass, like a waterfall); 8. A (searching a place thoroughly, often roughly); 9. B (a falling mass, like a waterfall); 10. C (to belittle; to speak of as unimportant); 11. D (an entrance hall); 12. A (conforming exactly or almost exactly to fact or to a standard or performing with total accuracy)

Essay assignments

Essay: Sacrificial love

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Gift of the Magi teaches about sacrificial love. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops sacrificial love across The Gift of the Magi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of sacrificial love. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Gift of the Magi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of sacrificial love, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Gift of the Magi's treatment of sacrificial love in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi. Name your critical

method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on sacrificial love in The Gift of the Magi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Wealth and poverty

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Gift of the Magi teaches about wealth and poverty. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops wealth and poverty across The Gift of the Magi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of wealth and poverty. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Gift of the Magi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of wealth and poverty, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Gift of the Magi's treatment of wealth and poverty in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on wealth and poverty in The Gift of the Magi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Irony of giving

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Gift of the Magi teaches about irony of giving. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how O. Henry develops irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how O. Henry develops irony of giving across The Gift of the Magi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Gift of the Magi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of irony of giving. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how O. Henry's choices in The Gift of the Magi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of irony of giving, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Gift of the Magi's treatment of irony of giving in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on irony of giving in The Gift of the Magi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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